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**EVALUATE THE IMPACT OF CORPORATE SOCIAL
RESPONSIBILITY PRACTICES ON COMPANY
PERFORMANCE AT NESTLE LANKA:
BASED ON CARROLL'S PYRAMID OF CSR**

MBA Research Proposal

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CHAPTER 1 - INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background to the Research Topic

Corporate Social Responsibility has become an important strategic necessity of companies that are present in the modern business environment (Waddock et al., 2002). The fact that CSR practices are being incorporated as part of the core business practices is a radical departure of the traditional approach of shareholder-centricity to the more holistic stakeholder-centricity approach. This change is indicative of increasing awareness of the fact that to achieve sustainable business performance, there must be a balance between the economic performance and social and environmental factors.

CSR has been experiencing great momentum in the last 20 years in the Sri Lankan context due to several reasons such as globalization, heightened stakeholder expectations, regulation, and the rise in awareness of the environmental and social issues. The growing pressure on multinational corporations that are currently operating in Sri Lanka, especially in the fast-moving consumer goods sector, is to ensure that they demonstrate that they are engaged in responsible business practices without compromising on their performance (Don Manuelge Dona, 2024).

Nestle Lanka, a branch of the famous Nestle Group, is an important case study to investigate the CSR-performance relationships within the Sri Lankan FMCG industry (Nestle, 2025). Being one of the most successful food and beverage companies in the country that has operations that cover a period of more than forty years, Nestle Lanka has put in place a number of CSRs initiatives including environmental sustainability, community development, employees' welfare and ethical business practices. The broad portfolio of CSR of the company covers nutrition education programs, water conservation programs, sustainable agriculture programs and rural development programs.

A well-known theoretical framework to understand and assess CSR practices was introduced by Carroll in 1991, the Pyramid of Corporate Social Responsibility. This is the model that conceptualizes CSR as having four different but related responsibilities: economic responsibilities (be profitable), legal responsibilities (obey the law), ethical responsibilities (be ethical) and philanthropic responsibilities (be a good corporate citizen). This paradigm has become one of the

most referred to and empirically validated models in the CSR literature, which provides a systematic method of evaluating organizational commitment towards social responsibility.

In spite of the fact that the CSR-performance relationship is widely studied all around the world, the gap in the knowledge of the impact of the four-dimensional CSR framework of Carroll on the performance of a company in the context of Sri Lankan FMCG remains huge. Majority of the existing Sri Lankan CSR research is based on banking industry or has applied the legitimacy theory approaches, with systematic case studies of CSR effects on FMCG company performance based on Carroll model still lacking.

1.2 Statement of the Problem

The main issue that the given research is trying to solve is the absence of empirical data on the connection between the four dimensions of CSR provided by Carroll and the performance of the company in the context of the Sri Lankan FMCG sector, in this case, Nestle Lanka. Although positive CSR-performance correlations have been shown to be generally positive in a global literature, context-specific factors such as cultural values, institutional environment and industry specificities play a key moderating role in these associations.

There are a number of important gaps in the existing knowledge. First, the pyramid framework of Carroll is not empirically validated in the context of the Sri Lankan organizations. Second, it is not clear how each CSR dimension has a relative weight and impact on various performance measures. Third, there is no evidence-based information on how the practitioners should prioritize CSR investments to achieve the best performance results. Lastly, the processes by which the CSR practices can be converted into actual business performance under the emerging market conditions need to be explored further.

The chosen research problem is especially important since the companies in Sri Lanka tend to invest a great part of their resources in CSR activities, but the performance outcomes of these investments have yet to be properly reported. In the case of Nestle Lanka and other MNCs in Sri Lanka, the knowledge of which aspects of the CSR framework are most apt to produce company performance can be used to design more strategic and effective CSR programs.

1.3 Research Questions

This research is guided by one primary research question and four specific sub-questions:

Primary Research Question:

To what extent do Corporate Social Responsibility practices, based on Carroll's Pyramid, impact company performance at Nestle Lanka?

Specific Research Questions:

1. What is the current level of implementation of each CSR dimension (economic, legal, ethical, philanthropic) at Nestle Lanka?
2. What is the relationship between each individual CSR dimension and different company performance indicators?
3. Which CSR dimension demonstrates the strongest influence on overall company performance at Nestle Lanka?
4. What are the strategies that can be implemented by the company based on CSR to improve its performances

1.4 Objectives

Primary Objective:

To evaluate the impact of Corporate Social Responsibility practices on company performance at Nestle Lanka using Carroll's Pyramid of CSR as the theoretical framework.

Specific Objectives:

1. To assess the extent of CSR practices implementation across Carroll's four dimensions (economic, legal, ethical, philanthropic responsibilities) at Nestle Lanka.
2. To determine the relationship between each CSR dimension and overall company performance through statistical analysis.
3. To identify which CSR responsibility dimension contributes most significantly to enhanced company performance.
4. To provide evidence-based recommendations for CSR-driven performance improvement strategies at Nestle Lanka.

1.5 Significance of the Study

This study has a considerable implication on various stakeholder groups. To practitioners, this study offers practical actionable knowledge to strategic investment in CSR. Managers of companies like Nestle Lanka dealing with FMCG will be able to get empirically proven evidence of what CSR dimensions would provide the highest returns to performance thus will be able to allocate resources more effectively and prioritize programs.

This study has practical implications to CSR managers because it has identified specific performance-based CSR practices that are unique to the Sri Lankan FMCG. This fact can be used to design, implement and evaluate CSR programs and go beyond the compliance-based methods to more strategically aligned programs that produce shared value to both the business and the society.

To policy makers and regulatory bodies in Sri Lanka, this study provides empirical evidence towards policy formulation of CSR. Knowledge of the business case of CSR based on local context may be used to shape incentive systems, reporting standards and regulatory systems that promote voluntary adoption of CSR and ensure that the social and environmental impact is significant.

CHAPTER 2 - LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Review on Dependent Variable - Company Performance

Company performance is a multidimensional construct which includes a number of indicators of organizational performance and success. Modern literature acknowledges that performance assessment needs to take into account various dimensions of performance instead of financial performance. Alshehhi et al., (2018) performed a systematic review of 132 high-quality journal articles that study the CSR-performance relationships, where the Return on Assets is the most commonly used proxy of profitability, then Return on Equity, Return on Investment, Earnings Per Share, and Tobin Q.

The financial performance indicators are the measures of the economic outcomes and value creation. ROA is used to show the efficiency with which a company uses its assets to produce profit and ROE measures returns to shareholders. Market-based interventions such as the Q by Tobin, reflect investor expectations of future performance possibilities through the relationship between market value and asset replacement cost. In their panel regression study, Aydoğmuş et al., (2023) used ROA as the dependent variable used in accounting performance and Q as the dependent variable used in market performance to examine the 46 Turkish companies and found significant positive effects of sustainability reporting on both measures.

In addition to financial indicators, efficiency, productivity, and quality indicators are operational performance. These are indicators of operational excellence and effectiveness of internal processes. Market performance indicators entail the growth of market share, brand equity, customer satisfaction and competitive positioning. Structural equation modeling by Hongming et al. (2020) revealed that the CSR practices have a significant impact on competitive advantage, which, in turn, affects both the accounting-based (ROE, EPS) and market-based (Tobin's Q) measures.

The organizational performance indicators reflect human capital outcomes in terms of employee satisfaction, retention rates, innovation capacity and organizational learning. These measures continue to gain acceptance as key performance dimensions and especially so with the increased emphasis on knowledge-based competitive advantages. Paun (2023) has conducted a survey of

431 Romanian employees, employing structural equation modelling, that has proven that perceived CSR has a direct and an indirect effect on organizational financial performance by increasing employee commitment and engagement.

Yapa Abeywardhana and Kavirathne (2023) studied the financial performance of listed commercial banks in the Sri Lankan context in terms of accounting-based (ROA, ROE, Profit After Tax) and market-based (Price-to-Earnings ratio, Earnings Per Share, Market-to-Book ratio) measures. Their fixed-effect panel regression analysis indicated that CSR substantially enhances market-based performance indicators and has less strong influences on accounting-based measures, indicating that CSR generates value in terms of improving market perceptions and confidence by stakeholders.

2.2 Review on Independent Variable: Corporate Social Responsibility

Corporate Social Responsibility entails the responsibilities and voluntary activities that organizations engage in to cater to the social, environmental and ethical issues in the course of their business activities. In 1991 (and later revised in later works), Carroll proposed a conceptual framework of CSR, the Pyramid of CSR, which divides the four levels of responsibility into four distinct, but interrelated levels: economic, legal, ethical, and philanthropic.

The base of the pyramid of economic responsibilities is that corporations need to be profitable and generate economic value as their core responsibility to both the shareholders and the society. This dimension involves cost effectiveness, profit maximization, shareholder value creation and economic sustainability. The first operationalized empirical attempt to measure the ideas of the Carroll framework came in a forced-choice measure given to 241 Forbes 500 CEOs by Aupperle et al., (1985), which established the content validity of the four-part classification.

Organizational legal obligations make organizations adhere to the stipulated laws and regulations that govern business activities. The dimension incorporates compliance with labor legislations, environmental laws, product safety and consumer protection laws and tax compliance. Legal CSR is the codified expectations of the society towards responsible business behavior and sets the standards that are acceptable.

Ethical responsibilities are the behaviors and practices that the society anticipates of organizations besides the law. This aspect incorporates a fair business conduct, honest marketing, fair treatment of suppliers and business associates, anti-corruption policies, and openness in operations. Carroll (2016) explained in his retrospective review that all pyramid levels are riddled with ethical responsibilities, and they cannot be considered a specific hierarchical level, but a set of principles that govern all the dimensions of CSR.

Philanthropic responsibilities are voluntary corporate citizenship activities such as community development programs, educational, healthcare, environmental conservation activities and charitable contributions. Although discretionary, these activities are beneficial to society and increase the reputation of corporations. In a survey of 400 participants, Baden (2016) discovered that the current perception of stakeholders reverses the original Carroll hierarchy, placing ethical duties as the most important, with economic concerns coming second, and may indicate the changing views on the role of corporations in the society.

Carroll has cross-cultural applications that demonstrate differences in contexts. Institutional voids and priorities of stakeholders in developing economies were illustrated by Visser (2006) who revealed that in the African context, philanthropic obligations become second in the hierarchy above legal and ethical aspects. This conclusion has implications on the emerging market CSR studies such as the case of Sri Lanka.

Specifically, in the FMCG sector Nirino et al., (2020) tested 190 international food and beverage corporations revealing that social CSR performance increases firm performance but has mixed impacts on environmental performance. Ikram et al. (2020) contrasted the CSR management system of South Asian and Western food companies, showing that the latter has a much higher level of effectiveness and adaptation, and that western ones are much more systematic in applying CSR to the core processes.

2.3 Theoretical Underpinning

The Pyramid of Corporate Social Responsibility by Carroll is the theoretical basis of the research. Carroll (1979, 1991) developed the concept of CSR to include economic, legal, ethical, and philanthropic support which organizations should handle concurrently. The framework offers a

systematic way of operationalizing and measuring the CSR practices and the multi-faculty aspect of the corporate social responsibilities.

The theoretical background is also informed by the stakeholder theory that assumes organizations should take into account and reconcile the interests of various stakeholder groups other than shareholders. Freeman (1984) has argued that the management of stakeholders helps in the long-term success of an organization by creating trust, legitimacy, and social capital. CSR practices operationalize the stakeholder engagement through the consideration of various concerns of different stakeholders in the economic, legal, ethical and philanthropic spheres.

The resource-based view theory is a complement to this framework and it explains how CSR practices may lead to competitive advantages. Barney (1991) proposed the superior performance to be driven by valuable, rare, inimitable, and non-substitutable resources. Such intangible resources that fit these criteria and can possibly create enduring competitive advantage are CSR capabilities especially ethical culture, stakeholder relationships and corporate reputation.

According to the good management theory, which is proposed by Waddock and Graves (1997), CSR indicates the quality of management in general. Companies that have better management performance have better CSR performance and hence better financial performance. This two-way interaction means that CSR indicates as well as supports organizational excellence.

Legitimacy theory offers another theoretical basis especially in the Sri Lankan context. Organizations undertake CSR to ensure that their activities are aligned with their expectation in the society and as a result, achieve legitimacy to survive and succeed. Beddewela and Herzig (2013) discovered the internal legitimacy pressure on MNC subsidiaries in Sri Lanka influences the way they report their CSR, which proves the contextual relevance of the theory.

2.4 Empirical Review on the Relationships

Empirical studies have shown that the relationships between CSR and company performance are predominantly positive, with effect sizes and mediating processes differing. The most influential meta-analysis, which was performed by Orlitzky et al., (2003) was an amalgamation of 520 of those studies and included 33,878 observations, which were not corrected by Hunter-Schmidt psychometrics. They found corrected correlation of about 0.36 corporate social performance and

corporate financial performance; stronger interrelations being found using accounting-based versus market-based measures.

Other more recent meta-analytic studies such as by Li et al., (2025) provide a review of 223 studies between 1984-2023 and found that, on the whole, CSR-performance relationships are found to be positive but stronger in the developing economies. This mediating role of economic development indicates that CSR can provide exceptionally high-performance returns in emerging markets such as Sri Lanka, where the expectations of stakeholders and institutional environments are not similar to those of developed markets.

In their study, Saeidi et al. (2015) used structural equation modeling with 205 manufacturing companies in Iran, which operationalized CSR in the economic and ethical dimensions of Carroll with a 29-item scale. They determined that CSR does not directly affect financial performance but works through complete mediation through competitive advantage, reputation and customer satisfaction. This observation implies that CSR indirectly generates value by boosting intangible resources and positioning.

The research that is industry-specific gives more context. In the study by Ahmad, Hidthiir and Rahman (2024), 75 Malaysian halal food companies were analyzed with dynamic GMM methodology, which showed significant positive impacts of CSR disclosure on both ROA and the Q of Tobin. This Asian emerging-market food industry research is quite similar to the proposed research context and the research methodology and indicates the viability and topicality of exploring CSR-performance relationships at Nestle Lanka.

Cho et al., (2019) conducted an analysis of 191 Korean-listed companies based on KEJI CSR index, and ROA and Q as dependent variables, which found partial positive correlations between each of the dimensions of CSR and performance measure. This dimensional analysis shows that various CSR elements have varying impacts on various performance measures and that it is important to study the Carroll four dimensions independently.

Empirical evidence in Sri Lanka is scarce yet increasing. Wijewardene and Munasinghe (2024) studied consumer attitude towards MNE CSR practices in the Sri Lankan FMCG industry with 200 consumers and structural equation modeling. They established that the perceptions of CSR

play an important role in purchase intentions mediated by brand image and brand attitude along with perceived quality, indicating the market-performance implications of CSR in the local context.

A study by Beddewela and Khan (2006) clearly used the four-part model of Carroll to compare the local and multinational companies in Sri Lanka and discovered that MNCs have a better CSR implementation across all the four dimensions. This comparative analysis not only formed the applicability of the framework developed by Carroll to the Sri Lankan context but also found institutional and capability distinctions in the local and multinational firms.

CHAPTER 3 - METHODOLOGY

3.1 Conceptual Framework and Hypothesis

The conceptual framework for this research positions Carroll's four CSR dimensions as independent variables influencing company performance as the dependent variable. Company performance is operationalized as a single construct measured through multiple indicators across financial, operational, and market dimensions.

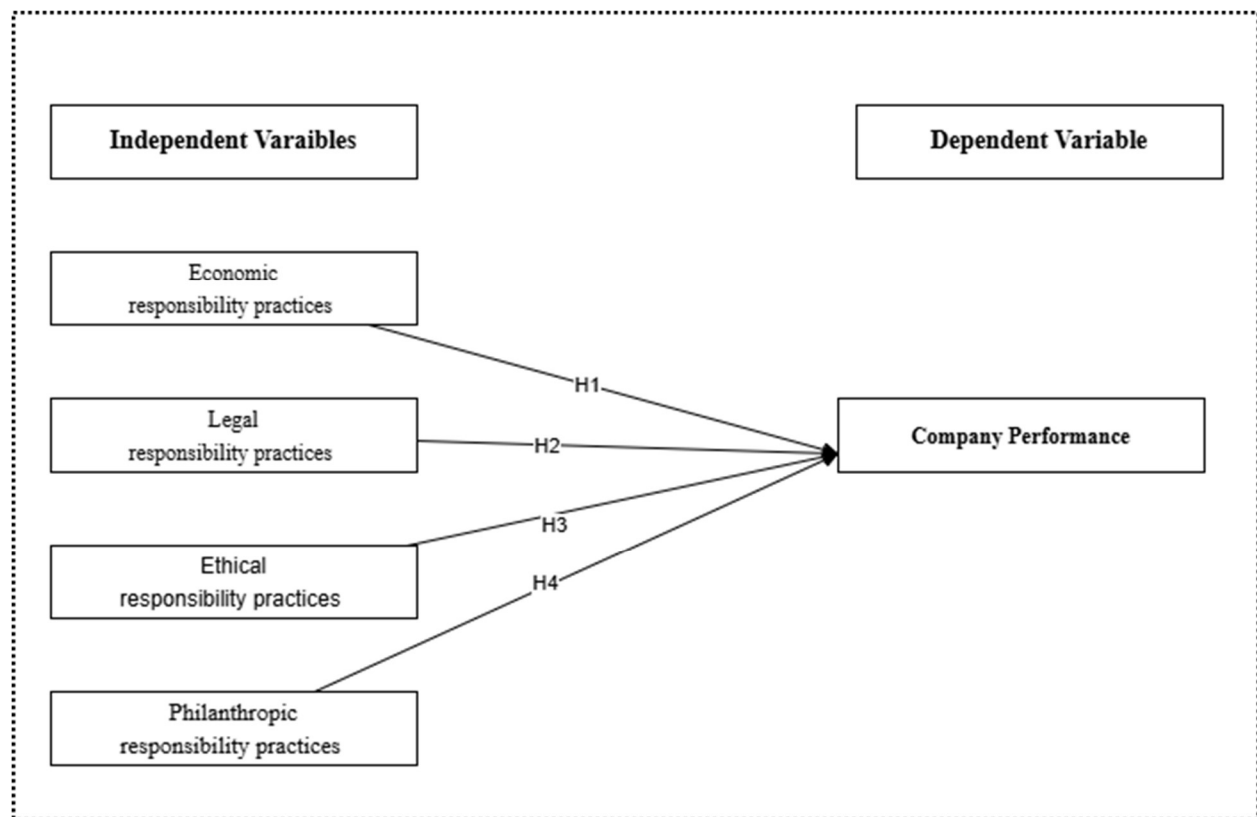


Figure 1: Conceptual Framework

Research Hypotheses:

H1: Economic responsibility practices have a significant positive impact on company performance at Nestle Lanka.

H2: Legal responsibility practices have a significant positive impact on company performance at Nestle Lanka.

H3: Ethical responsibility practices have a significant positive impact on company performance at Nestle Lanka.

H4: Philanthropic responsibility practices have a significant positive impact on company performance at Nestle Lanka.

3.2 Research Philosophy

The study has a positivist philosophical approach, which is in line with quantitative research that involves study of relationships between variables that can be measured objectively. Positivism presupposes that there is such thing as social reality that does not depend on human perception and can be explored by systematic observation and measurement (Park et al., 2020). This philosophical stance is consistent with the research aims of statistically testing hypothesized associations between CSR practices and company performance.

The epistemological assumption of the study is that information regarding CSR-performance relationships can be produced by using empirical observation and statistical data analysis. This position supports the application of structured questionnaires, standardized measurement scale, and quantitative methods of analysis to test the hypotheses based on the existing theoretical frameworks.

The ontological standpoint presupposes that CSR practices and company performance are objective phenomena, which can be measured and quantified using validated tools. Although perceptions of CSR and performance could be different across stakeholders, the study assumes both of these constructs as having an objective reality that can be measured and evaluated in a systematic manner (Malhotra and Grover, 1998).

3.3 Research Approach and Strategy

This study uses a deductive method, which is a hypothesis which is tested using the CSR theory advanced by Carroll and available empirical data. The deductive reasoning proceeds with general theoretical propositions to particular empirical observations, which can then be tested and refined by empirical findings of the Nestle Lanka context (Hall et al., 2023).

The study design is a cross-sectional survey with quantitative analysis. With this approach, one will be able to gather a systematic set of data on various categories of respondents at Nestle Lanka, offering a wide range of views on CSR practices and company performance (Rindfleisch et al.,

2008). The cross-sectional design gives a representation of the existing state relationships between variables providing useful insights to practitioners but with limitations to causal inferences.

The study design is descriptive and correlational, as it seeks to record the level of CSR practice and analyse statistical correlations with performance measures. Experimental designs offer better causal information but in real life and organizational contexts, because of practical and ethical considerations, correlational methods used in management research are necessary.

3.4 Population and Sampling

The target population includes stakeholders at Nestle Lanka that have the knowledge of the companies CSR practices and performance results. This group comprises senior management, middle management, employees in different departments, suppliers and representatives of the community that are involved in the CSR programs at Nestle Lanka.

Stratified random sampling will be used to have a representation of the various stakeholders. The sampling frame will be designed in collaboration with the management of Nestle Lanka to determine the available respondents' groups in each stratum. Stratification will help to capture the perspectives of various organizational levels and groups of stakeholders sufficiently.

The sample size will be 100-150 respondents which will be divided into strata as follows: senior management (10-20 respondents), middle management (30-40 respondents), employees (40-50 respondents), suppliers (10-20 respondents), and community stakeholders (10-20 respondents). This sample size has sufficient statistical power to perform a multiple regression analysis, and is manageable due to resource and access limitations.

The determination of sample size involves the accepted standards of multivariate analysis that includes minimum ratio of observations to independent variables.

3.5 Data Collection Methods

The primary data will be gathered by using a structured self-administered questionnaire in three main sections. Section A will entail demographic data such as respondent category, department, number of years working with the company and level of position. In section B, CSR practices are

evaluated based on scaled versions of four dimensions of Carroll. Section C measures the performance impression of the company in financial, operational and market aspects.

Every CSR and performance item will use five-point Likert scale (1 to 5 Strongly Disagree to Strongly Agree) as conventions in CSR research. This scaling method is easy to statistically analyze, and it offers enough variation of responses to identify relationships.

The questionnaire shall be piloted with 25-30 respondents who have different stakeholder categories. Pilot testing will be used to measure the clarity of the instruments, time of completion and initial reliability. Pilot responses will be used to refine the questionnaire, and then full-scale data collection will take place.

3.6 Data Analysis Methods

The stages of data analysis will be carried out in SPSS Statistics software. The preliminary data analysis will involve screening of missing values, outliers, and normality. Descriptive statistics will be used to describe the demographics of the respondents, and to compute means and standard deviations of all the CSR and performance variables.

The reliability test will be done using the Cronbach alpha coefficient of each multi-item scale, and the minimum coefficient of 0.70 will be used as the acceptable limit. The validity analysis will incorporate content validity by having the experts review it, convergent validity by conducting a factor analysis and discriminant validity by conducting inter-construct correlation analysis.

An index of the company performance will be built through the averaging of the scores in the financial, operational and market performance indicators. As a holistic measure of performance, this composite measure offers an analysis of dimensional performance outcomes which can be done on a supplementary basis.

GANTT CHART

Activity	April			May		
	2ndWeek	3rd Week	4th Week	1st Week	2nd Week	3rd Week
Literature Review						
Questionnaire Development						
Pilot Testing						
Data Collection						
Data Analysis						
Report Writing & Submission						

Table 1: Gantt Chart

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